1.3 Populist Tactics to Oppose IOs

Populists' opposition to IOs manifests in a variety of ways. Because the main contribution of this book is to uncover how IOs respond to populist attacks, we must first understand the nature of these attacks. We therefore discuss how populists oppose IOs briefly here, providing further explanation in chapter 2 and empirical testing of these tactics in chapter 3. We also touch on several key examples to fix ideas in this chapter, which we flesh out in the case studies found in chapter 8.

The populist backlash against IOs ranges from subtle resistance to dramatic actions. Some populists seek to reshape IOs from within, while others endeavor to dismantle them from the outside. Unfortunately for IOs, populists often implement a multitude of these strategies simultaneously. Moreover, different leaders adopt diverse approaches, subjecting IOs to a barrage of such measures.

The specific strategies chosen by a given populist are contingent on the populist's objectives and constraints. For example, state power is one important factor that shapes the form of populist resistance. Powerful states have many levers they can pull to weaken IOs, such as cutting off funds or reducing their participation in the organizations. Weaker states, meanwhile, typically affect IOs to a lesser extent. That said, small countries that oppose IOs can band together to damage organizations (Helfer 2004; Pratt 2021); for example, several smaller states joined forces to counter the International Criminal Court (ICC), as we show in chapter 8. Defections by small states can also trigger chain reactions, and small states may possess outsize power given institutional rules such as unanimous decision making and leadership rotation (Arias, Clark, and Kaya 2024). Indeed, Hungary often blocks the EU's actions because of requirements of unanimity, and temporary members of the UN Security Council wield significant influence. As such, both the number of populist member states resisting an IO and the collective power possessed by such states can determine the potential harm inflicted on an organization. We discuss these considerations further in chapters 2 and 3.

1.3.1 Insights from Organizational Sociology

In exploring how populist actors resist international organizations (IOs), we draw on insights from organizational sociology, which examines how hostile